

**WHEN WE GO TO TEMPLES, PRAYING TO AN IDOL FEELS LIKE A BIG DEAL – A MARVEL, A MIRACLE. BUT THESE MEDALS AREN'T LIKE THAT. THEY'RE REAL. PEOPLE TOUCHING THEM SHOULD REALISE THAT THIS IS SOMETHING THEY CAN WORK TOWARD AND ACHIEVE.**

management" is his best trait, and Sreejesh reveals that he has saved nearly 80% of his hockey earnings. This financial caution stems from the challenges Sreejesh and his family faced early in his career.

"My father was a farmer. We never went hungry; there was always food at home. But there wasn't any extra money. The first time I needed to buy an advanced goalkeeping kit was when we felt the financial pinch.

"I think I reached this level because of those early struggles. If everything is readily available, you don't appreciate its value. I am who I am today because of what I've been through," he explains.

The need for financial security was always a looming concern in his early career, but the pressure eased when Sreejesh was employed by the Indian Overseas Bank in 2006.

"That job was a huge relief. It allowed me to focus on hockey because some of my worries were taken care of. I had a steady income, and if I got injured, I had a fallback. That gave me a lot of confidence.

"Sportspeople are like show horses. If you get injured, you're cast aside. No one really tracks what happens to you afterwards. I always tell younger athletes to get a job alongside their sports careers, for that sense of security," adds Sreejesh. Post-Olympic fame has also brought an explosion of brand endorsements and nationwide attention to the 36-year-old. But Sreejesh isn't easily dazzled by fame.

"This fame didn't appear overnight. It's not like I won a lottery.

I've been playing hockey for 24 years and have been part of the Indian team for nearly 20.

Over that time, I've developed the ability to handle the attention I'm getting now."

The one thing that hasn't come his way is a film role. Aneeshya interjects with a laugh, "He can act in a movie if he wants, as long as there are no heroines in it."

"There were talks about a biopic at some point, but it didn't materialise," Sreejesh says. When asked who he'd

want to portray him, he casually adds, "I don't have a special preference, but Tovino Thomas has the stardom and the physique." Retirement hasn't slowed him down much. He's been flying around the country and abroad, attending felicitations, promo shoots, and sponsorship events.

"I can't tell the difference [post-retirement] because he's still not home most of the time," Aneeshya jokes.

His coaching stint with the junior

